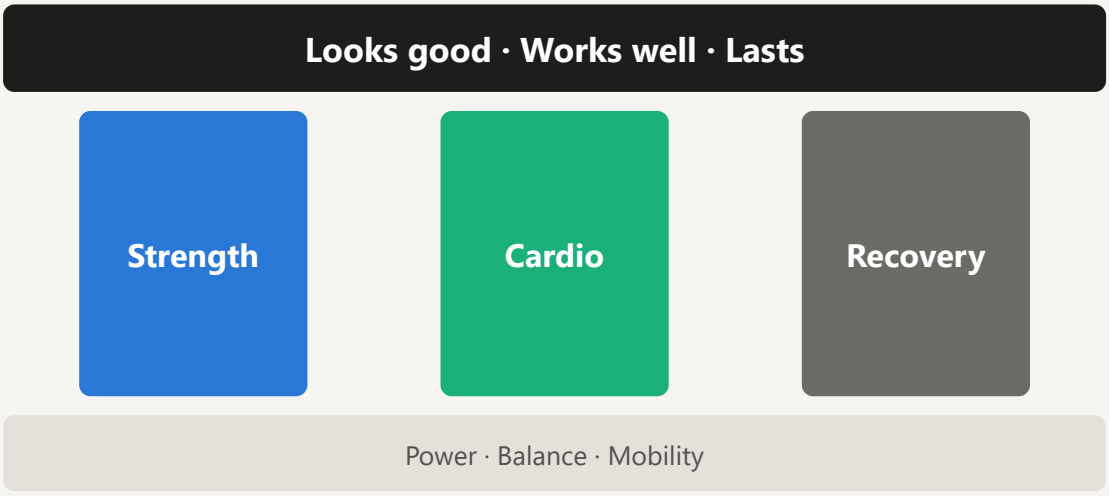
BÓ JĪ (薄肌) THEORY · SUSTAINABLE EDITION · V1.1

The Sustainable Lean Physique Handbook

A body that looks good, works well, and lasts



V1.1 · October 2026 · Released under CC BY 4.0: free to share and adapt with credit.

A general fitness guide for healthy adults, not medical advice. If you have a medical condition, an old injury, are pregnant, or take regular medication, check with a doctor first.

BEFORE YOU START

How to use this handbook

This is the sustainable edition of the “bó jī” (lean physique) theory. Understand the goal, pick a program, and follow it. Every number here is a starting point, not a rule. Adjust to your own situation.

If you want to know	Go to
What a lean physique is, and how much body fat	Chapter 1
What to train each week	Chapters 2 and 7
How to lift, and which program to pick	Chapters 3 and 4
How much cardio	Chapter 5
What to eat	Chapter 8
What to do when you stall or feel worn out	Chapters 9 and 10
Just the essentials	The cheat sheet on the last page

Check first

- Heart disease, high blood pressure, diabetes, an old joint injury, pregnancy, or long-term medication: **talk to a doctor first**, especially before intervals and jumping.
- Not sure? Fill in the free PAR-Q+ pre-exercise questionnaire.
- Haven't trained in a long time? Keep everything light and short for the first 2–4 weeks.

The pain traffic light

Learn to tell “tired” from “hurt.” Sore muscles are normal. Sore joints are not.

Green: keep going
Muscle burn, fatigue, heavy breathing; muscle soreness 1–2 days after training.

Yellow: adjust
Mild joint discomfort (3 out of 10 or less) that is gone by the next day. **Lower the weight, shorten the range, or swap to a pain-free exercise.**

Red: stop
Sharp pain, pain that builds as you train or is worse the next day, numbness or swelling. **Stop training that area and see a doctor or physical therapist.**

The principles behind this handbook

- Doing it for years beats doing it perfectly for a few weeks.
- Watch trends, not single days.
- On busy weeks, doing less still counts. Don't drop the whole week because you can't do it all.

CHAPTER 1

The goal: what “lean physique” means

Lean physique = enough muscle + moderate body fat. The aim is a body that looks good, works well, and is easy to keep, not a particular number.

There are only two levers

Strength training builds muscle. **Managing calories** brings body fat down. There is no special “lean physique” workout. Strength, cardio, and balance make that muscle quick, stable, and hard to injure.

Body fat guide

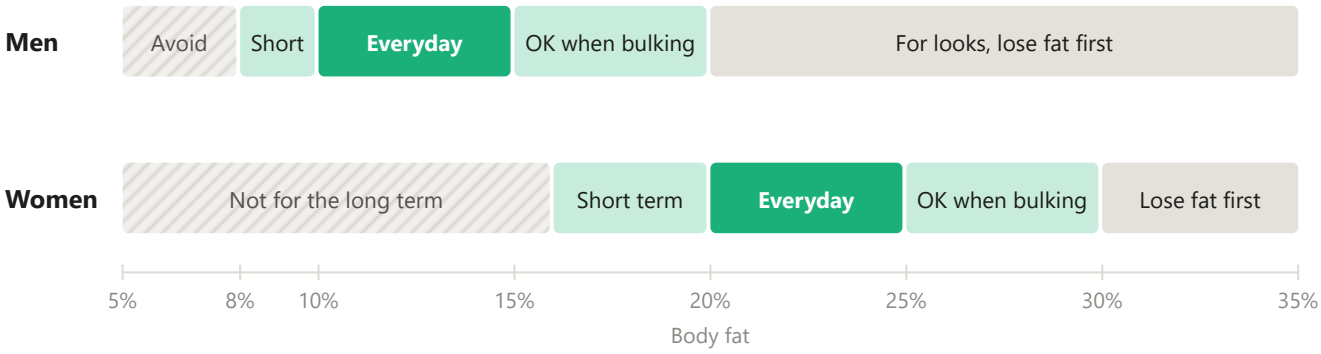


Figure 1. Body fat as a guide to looks. These are appearance targets, not health cut-offs. The range you can hold comfortably differs from person to person.

- **Everyday:** about 10–15% for men and 20–25% for women. Most people can eat enough, train hard, and sleep well here.
- **Short-term dips:** you can lean out briefly for a photo shoot or event, then return to everyday levels. This step is optional.
- **Body fat devices are imprecise:** scales and handheld analyzers are often off by several percentage points. **Waist size, photos, and long-term trends** are more reliable.

A simpler health check

Keep your waist under half your height. At 170 cm (5’7”), aim for a waist under 85 cm (33.5”). Measure at the navel after a relaxed breath out.

Signals that matter more than body fat

These usually mean you're eating too little or training too much. They apply to men and women:

- Irregular or missing periods, clearly lower sex drive
- Always tired, often sick, injured again and again
- Training performance keeps sliding

Eat a bit more and train a bit less. If it doesn't improve, see a doctor.

CHAPTER 2

Train six things, but not equally

Strength, cardio, and recovery are the three pillars. Give them real time. Power, balance, and mobility need only small doses, slotted into warm-ups and gaps in your program.

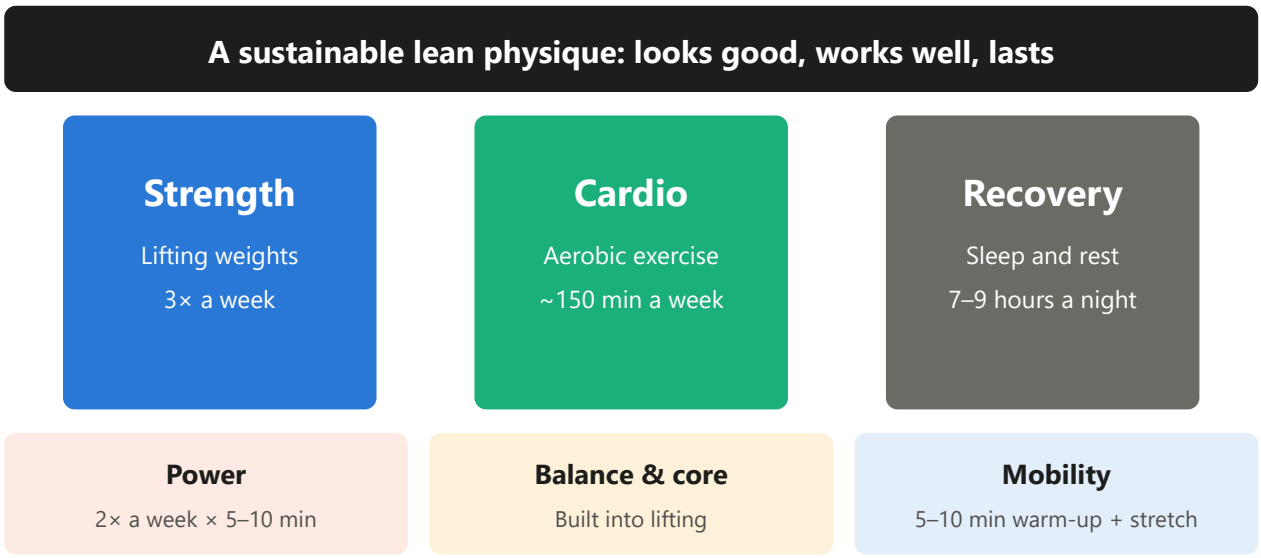


Figure 2. Three pillars and three small doses. The pillars hold the body up; the small doses make it steadier and more agile.

Element	Why it matters	How	Weekly minimum
Strength	Looks, metabolism, staying independent as you age	Compound lifts, adding load slowly	3 sessions
Cardio	Heart health, faster recovery, a longer life	Mostly moderate, a little vigorous	150 min moderate or 75 min vigorous
Recovery	Makes the other five actually work	Sleep, deload weeks, managing stress	7–9 hours a night
Power	Quick reactions; declines fastest after 40	Jumps, throws, short sprints	2 × 5–10 min
Balance & core	Single-leg stability; fewer sprains, falls, and back pain	Single-leg moves, anti-rotation	Built into lifting
Mobility	Clean technique, comfortable joints	Dynamic warm-up, post-workout stretching	5–10 min per session

You only need enough flexibility to do each exercise properly. Extra stretching doesn't clearly prevent injuries, so don't spend a lot of time on it.

CHAPTER 3

Strength training: five rules

Learn these five and they work with any program.

#	Rule	Notes
1	**Train each muscle twice a week**	Works better than once a week, and missing a day doesn't wipe out the week.
2	**About 10 sets per muscle per week**	Beginners grow on 6–8. Warm-up sets don't count.
3	**Stop each set with 1–3 reps left in the tank**	Too easy doesn't count; going to failure every set is too draining. See Figure 3.
4	**Main lifts 6–10 reps, accessories 8–15**	Main lifts are big moves like squats, deadlifts, bench press, and rows. Accessories are small moves like lateral raises and curls.
5	**Progress with "double progression"**	Add reps first, then weight. See Figure 4.

After each set, ask: "How many more reps could I have done?"



Never take squats or deadlifts to 0. New lifters misjudge this, so leave 2–3 at first.

Figure 3. How hard each set should be. Most sets end with 1–3 reps still in the tank.

Double progression

Give each exercise a rep range, for example 8–10.

1. Keep the weight the same and try to add a rep or two each session.
2. Once every set reaches the top of the range (10), add weight next time and drop back to the bottom (8).
3. How much to add: 1–2.5 kg (2.5–5 lb) for upper body, 2.5–5 kg (5–10 lb) for lower body. For small moves like lateral raises and curls, adding weight is hard; just add reps.

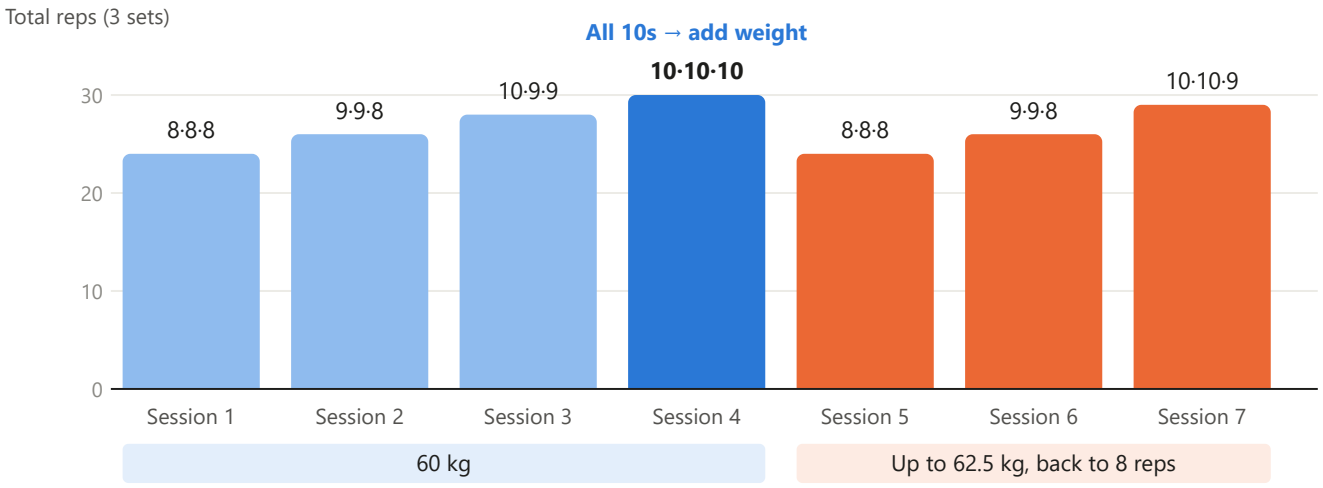
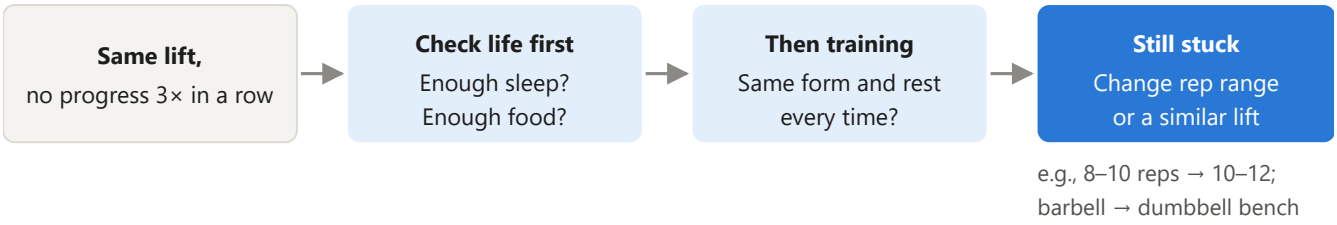


Figure 4. Double progression example (bench press, 8–10 reps, 3 sets). Reps climb until all three sets hit 10, then the weight goes up and reps start again from 8.

How each session runs

1. **Dynamic warm-up, 5–10 min** (Chapter 6).
2. **Power work, 5–10 min** (on the days it's scheduled).
3. **Main lifts:** 2–3 warm-up sets building up in weight, then your work sets. Rest 2–3 min between sets.
4. **Accessories:** rest 1–2 min; pair two exercises back to back (a superset) to save time.
5. **Stretch for 5 min** and log today's weights and reps.

When you stall



Two exceptions

- While cutting, holding your strength counts as success.
- Don't switch exercises too often, or you can't tell whether you're improving.

Figure 5. The order for fixing a stall. Most stalls are a sleep or food problem, not a program problem.

Deload weeks

About every 6–8 weeks, or earlier if you're clearly worn out, your joints ache, or you keep stalling: **halve your sets, keep the weight the same or a little lower**, for one week. Then go back to normal.

CHAPTER 4

Pick a program

Three sessions a week is enough for most people. What matters is hitting each muscle twice, about 10 sets a week, and sticking with it for years.

A · Beginner full body

3× a week · 45–60 min each

- Training less than 6 months
- Can't squat or deadlift yet
- Run it for 8–12 weeks

B · Standard 3-day (core plan)

3× a week · 60–75 min each

- Technique is solid
- Enough for most people for years
- Used in this handbook's weekly plan

C · Advanced 4-day

4× a week · 60–75 min each

- Training seriously 1–2+ years
- Diet and sleep on point, still stuck 2 months
- You really have 4 free days

Figure 6. Which program. Move left to right as you progress; step back when life gets busy.

A · Beginner full body (weeks 1–12)

Alternate days A and B, three times a week: A-B-A one week, B-A-B the next. Pick a light weight you could lift for 3 more reps, and focus on clean technique.

Day A	~13 sets
Goblet squat	3 × 8–12
Dumbbell bench press	3 × 8–12
Lat pulldown	3 × 8–12
Dumbbell Romanian deadlift	2 × 8–12
Plank	2 × 20–40 s

Day B	~13 sets
Leg press or split squat	3 × 8–12
Seated cable row	3 × 8–12
Dumbbell shoulder press	3 × 8–12
Hip thrust	2 × 10–15
Dead bug	2 × 8 per side

B · Standard 3-day: lower / upper / full body

Monday, Wednesday, Friday (or any three non-consecutive days). Main lifts 6–10 reps, accessories 8–15.

Monday · Lower body	15 sets · ~70 min incl. box jumps
Squat	4 × 6–10
Romanian deadlift	3 × 6–10
Bulgarian split squat (also trains balance)	3 × 8–12 per side
Leg curl	3 × 10–15
Pallof press (anti-rotation core)	2 × 10 per side

Wednesday · Upper body	23 sets · ~75 min incl. med ball
Bench press	4 × 6–10
Pull-up (lat pulldown if you can't do 6)	4 × 6–10
Standing overhead press	3 × 6–10
Bent-over row	3 × 8–12
Dip (close-grip push-up if you can't)	3 × 8–12
Lateral raise + biceps curl (superset)	3 × 10–15 each

Friday · Full body	20 sets · ~70 min
Incline dumbbell bench press	3 × 8–12
Front squat or leg press	3 × 8–12
Hip thrust	3 × 8–12
One-arm dumbbell row	3 × 8–12
Single-leg Romanian deadlift (also trains balance)	2 × 8–10 per side
Face pull + lateral raise (superset)	3 × 12–15 each

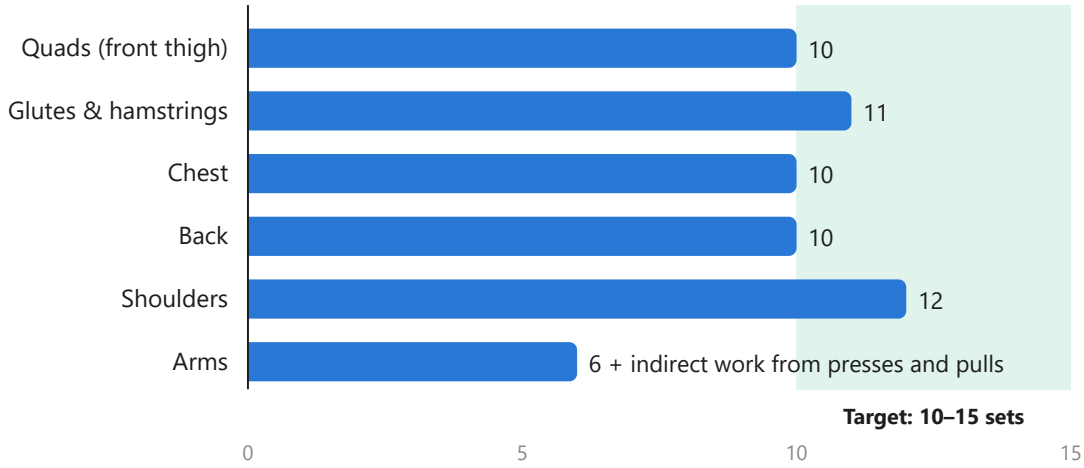


Figure 7. Direct weekly sets in the standard 3-day plan. Every major muscle gets two days and about 10 sets. Want more chest? Add 2 sets of flyes on Friday.

C · Advanced 4-day: upper / lower × 2

Monday upper A, Tuesday lower A, Thursday upper B, Friday lower B. About 12–16 sets per muscle per week. On four days, move cardio to rest days or do it after lifting.

Upper A	
Bench press	4 × 6–10
Pull-up	4 × 6–10
Standing overhead press	3 × 6–10
Bent-over row	3 × 8–12
Lateral raise + curl	3 × 10–15 each

Lower A	
Squat	4 × 6–10
Romanian deadlift	3 × 6–10
Leg curl	3 × 10–15
Calf raise	3 × 10–15
Hanging leg raise	3 × 8–12

Upper B	
Incline dumbbell bench press	3 × 8–12
Lat pulldown	3 × 8–12
One-arm dumbbell row	3 × 8–12
Dip	3 × 8–12
Face pull + lateral raise	3 × 12–15 each
Triceps extension	3 × 10–15

Lower B	
Deadlift or leg press	3 × 6–10
Bulgarian split squat	3 × 8–12 per side
Hip thrust	3 × 8–12
Single-leg Romanian deadlift	2 × 8–10 per side
Pallof press	2 × 10 per side

No equipment

Area	Exercises
Push	Push-up → feet-elevated push-up → close-grip push-up
Pull	Pull-up; no bar? Inverted rows under a sturdy table, band rows
Legs	Backpack squat, split squat, step-up, single-leg glute bridge
Making it harder	Add reps → slow the lowering to 3 s → load the backpack → harder variation

CHAPTER 5

Cardio

About 150 minutes of moderate cardio a week, or 75 of vigorous, or a mix. Count by intensity, not by the name of the activity.

Use the talk test to judge intensity

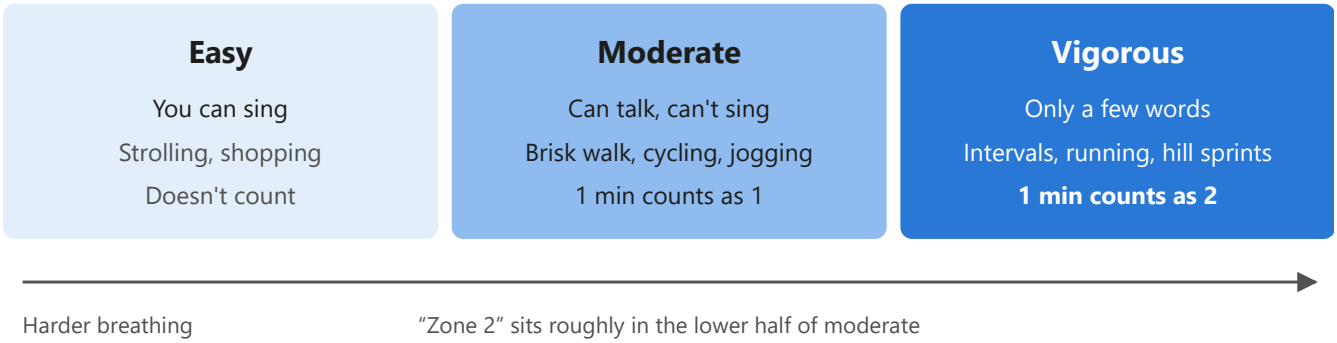


Figure 8. The talk test. No heart-rate monitor needed. If you have one, moderate is roughly 64–76% of max heart rate, but people vary a lot.

A simple mix

- **Moderate:** 2–3 times a week, 30–60 minutes each.
- **Vigorous:** once a week. For example, 4 rounds of "4 min hard, 3 min easy," about 30 minutes in all.
- **Daily steps:** keep walking 7,000–10,000 steps a day. Walking fast enough that you can't sing counts toward your cardio.
- **Low fitness to start?** Begin with incline walking. When it gets too easy to raise your heart rate, switch to jogging.

Type	Pros	Watch out
Incline walking	Lowest impact, easiest way to reach moderate	Fit people may struggle to raise their heart rate
Cycling	Low impact, least effect on leg training	Little stimulus for bones
Jogging	Efficient, good for bone density	Each landing is 2–3× body weight; better not the day after legs
Swimming	Almost zero impact	Least stimulus for bones
Sports, hiking	Fun, easy to stick with	Intensity jumps around; a rough estimate is fine

Will cardio hurt muscle growth?

Not at sensible amounts. If muscle is the priority, lift first and do cardio after on the same day; a few hours apart is even better, but not required. Running interferes with leg training more than cycling does.

CHAPTER 6

Power, mobility, and balance

None of these needs its own session. Spend 5–10 minutes on them inside your warm-up or lifting.

Power: twice a week, 5–10 minutes, right after the warm-up

Area	Exercise	Sets
Lower body	Box jump, standing broad jump	3 × 3–5
Upper body	Med-ball chest pass, overhead slam	3 × 5
Full body	Kettlebell swing; or 20–30 m (20–30 yd) sprints	3 × 10; sprints 4–6 runs

- **Every rep fast and clean; stop when you slow down.** This isn't cardio, so don't get out of breath.
- **Learn to land first:** knees over toes, land softly. Heavier, or knees bothering you? Use med-ball throws instead of jumps.
- **Sprints:** start at 70–80% speed and build up over a few weeks. If you've strained a hamstring before, sprint on a stationary bike instead.

Mobility: move before, stretch after

- **Before: dynamic warm-up (30–60 s each):** hip circles, world's greatest stretch, thoracic rotations, band shoulder circles. Skip long static stretches before lifting; they briefly sap strength.
- **After: static stretches (30–60 s each):** stretch what you trained, never into pain. If you sit a lot, pick two a day: hip flexors, chest, upper back, ankles.

Balance and core: built into lifting

- **At least 2 single-leg exercises a week:** Bulgarian split squat, single-leg Romanian deadlift, step-up.
- **One core exercise per session, 2–3 sets:** Pallof press, one-arm farmer's carry, plank, dead bug. These teach your trunk to stay still, which protects your back better than crunches.
- **Sneak it into daily life:** stand on one leg for 30 s while brushing your teeth; close your eyes once that's easy.

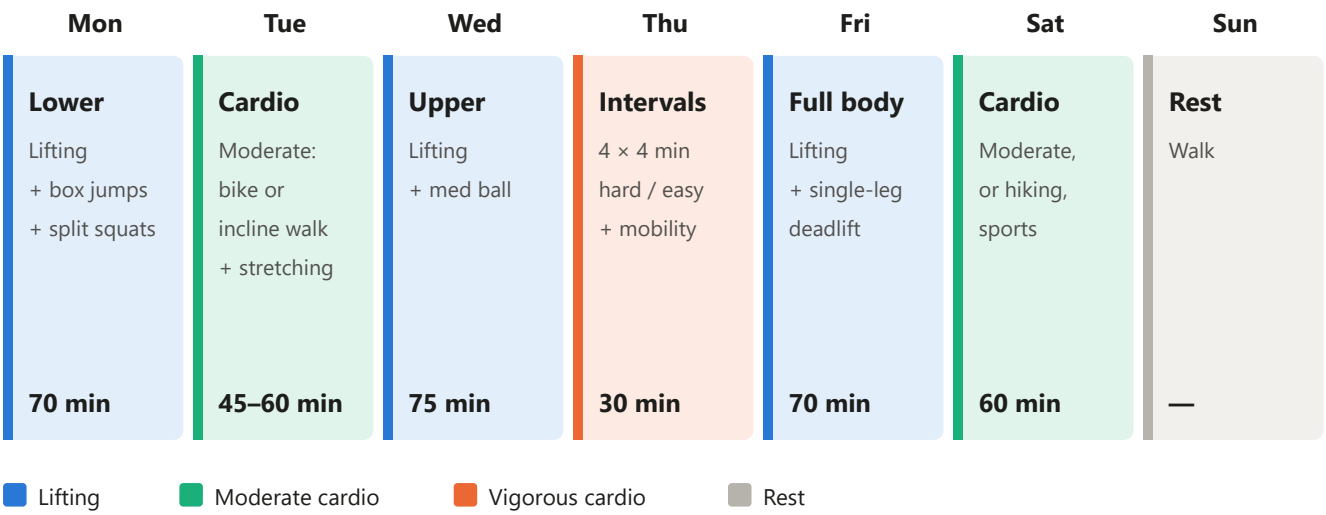
Self-checks (every 6–8 weeks)

Test	Pass	If you can't
Squat with heels down, thighs below parallel	Down and up with control	Work on ankle and hip mobility
Both arms straight overhead	Arms by your ears, no arched back	Work on thoracic rotation, shoulder circles
Stand on one leg	30 s eyes open with ease; about 10 s eyes closed (under 40)	More single-leg work and one-leg standing
Standing broad jump	Hold or beat your own mark	Keep up the twice-weekly power work

CHAPTER 7

Putting the week together

About 5–6 hours a week covers all six elements. Here's a sample week using the standard 3-day plan. Shuffle the days to fit your schedule.



Cardio total: ~105–120 min moderate + 16 min vigorous × 2 ≈ 140–150 min.
Add a few brisk walks on weekdays and you're past 150. Walk 7,000–10,000 steps a day on top.

Figure 9. Sample week. A rest day between lifting days; no vigorous cardio the day after legs.

Scheduling tips

- Leave about 48 hours before training the same muscle again. Shorter is fine if your next session doesn't suffer.
- Try not to run or do intervals the day after legs; cycling and brisk walking matter less.
- Finish hard training 1–2 hours before bed if you can.
- If your week gets disrupted, just shift things along. No need to make up missed sessions.

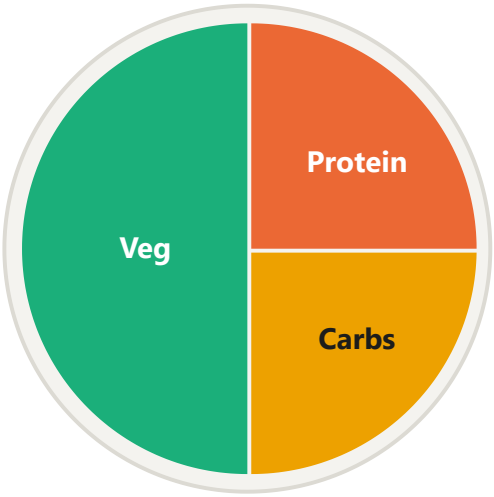
The busy-week minimum

2–3 full-body lifting sessions (40 min each, main lifts only) + 1–2 cardio sessions of 30 min. **Holding steady is a win.**

CHAPTER 8

Eating

Eat enough protein, set calories to match your goal, and keep it about 80% whole foods and 20% flexible.



Vegetables: half the plate
At least two fists; the more colors the better

Protein: a quarter (one palm)
Meat, fish, eggs, tofu, yogurt (25–40 g protein)

Carbs: a quarter (about one fist)
Rice, oats, potatoes; a bit more on training days

Healthy fats: one thumb
Olive oil, nuts, avocado; plus 2 fruits a day

Figure 10. Plate proportions for each meal. Don't want to count? Build every meal like this and you'll be close.

Protein

- **1.6–2.2 g per kg of body weight a day (0.7–1 g per lb)**. 1.6 is enough for most people. Spread it over 3–4 meals.
- **If you're overweight, use your goal weight**, not your current weight. Example: goal 70 kg (154 lb) → about 110–150 g a day, 30–40 g per meal.
- Sources: eggs, chicken breast, lean beef, fish, tofu, plain yogurt, milk. Fill gaps with whey protein.

Calories: start from where you are

Starting point	How to eat	Notes
Thin, want muscle	About 5–10% above maintenance	Gain about 0.5–1 kg (1–2 lb) a month; faster is mostly fat
Normal weight, not much muscle, new to lifting	Maintenance	Focus on training and your shape will improve; no need to diet
Higher body fat	10–20% below maintenance	Lose 0.5–1% of body weight a week
Obesity or a chronic condition	Plan it with a doctor or dietitian	Don't crash diet on your own

- **The closer you get, the slower you go:** if you're already lean and want to keep your muscle, about 0.5% a week is plenty. At 70 kg, that's about 0.35 kg (0.75 lb).
- **On long cuts**, return to maintenance for 1–2 weeks every 8–12 weeks to give body and mind a break.
- Fat at least 20% of calories; fiber 25–35 g a day; 3 servings of vegetables and 2 of fruit.

A sample day (goal weight 70 kg)

Meal	What	Protein
Breakfast	2 eggs, a cup of plain yogurt, a small bowl of oats	~30 g
Lunch	Palm of chicken or fish, half a plate of greens, fist of rice	~35 g
Snack	A glass of milk or unsweetened soy milk, 1 fruit	~10 g
Dinner	Palm of lean meat or tofu, half a plate of greens, fist of sweet potato	~35 g
If needed	A scoop of whey after training or before bed	~25 g
Total	Right inside the 110–150 g range	**~135 g**

Flexible rules

- **80% whole foods, 20% foods you love.** No need to quit sugar; keep added sugar under 10% of daily calories.
- **Plan dinners out and holidays into the week.** The next day, eat normally. No skipping meals to compensate.
- **Go easy on alcohol:** it's calorie-dense and hurts sleep and recovery.

Supplements

Item	How	Notes
Creatine	3–5 g a day	The best-supported supplement; any time of day
Whey protein	When protein falls short	It's just food in convenient form
Caffeine	At least 8 hours before bed	Boosts training performance, but late doses hurt sleep
Vitamin D	Get a blood test first	Low sun exposure makes deficiency more likely

CHAPTER 9

Sleep and recovery

Training is the stimulus; progress happens while you rest. If recovery can't keep up, more training only takes you backward.

Sleep: 7–9 hours a night

Short sleep drags down strength, muscle gain, and appetite control together, and you lose more muscle while cutting.

Routine

- Wake within the same 1-hour window every day, weekends included
- Put the phone down 30–60 min before bed, or at least dim it
- Finish hard training 1–2 hours before bed

Environment and drinks

- Dark, quiet, cool room (about 18–22°C / 64–72°F)
- No caffeine in the 8 hours before bed
- Alcohol disrupts deep sleep; keep it low while training

Managing recovery

- **Several nights under 6 hours:** train lighter that week. Don't push through.
- **High stress at work or home:** cut training volume by 20–30% and just hold steady. Stress stacks; your body can't tell which kind it is.
- **While cutting:** deficits beyond 25% usually hit recovery and strength hard.
- **Deload weeks:** about every 6–8 weeks, or earlier when fatigue builds (see Chapter 3).

Fatigue check (not a diagnosis)

If two or more of these show up, rest 2–3 days, then train easy for a week:

- Morning resting heart rate clearly higher than usual
- Strength sliding for two weeks straight
- Poor sleep, low motivation, getting sick easily

If rest doesn't help, or you also notice the “signals that matter more than body fat” from Chapter 1, see a doctor.

CHAPTER 10

Tracking progress

Judge looks by trends and ability by tests. Don't fixate on body fat alone.

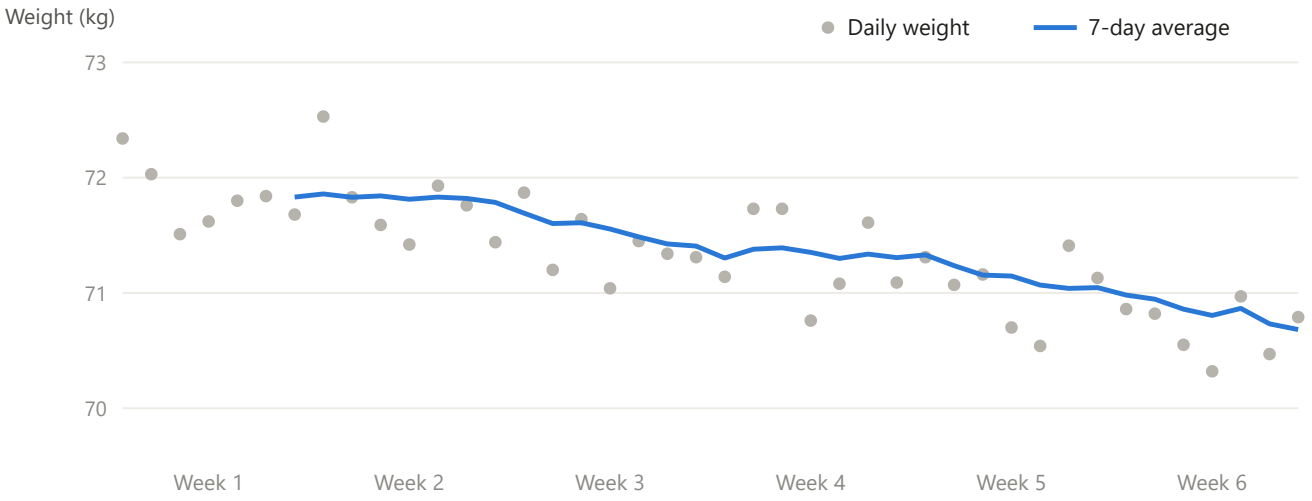


Figure 11. Daily weight bounces around (illustration). A single day can swing 1 kg, mostly water and food. Just watch where the 7-day average line is heading.

What	How	How often	Look for
Weight	On waking, after the bathroom	Daily	Change in the weekly average
Waist	At the navel, after a relaxed breath out	Every 2 weeks	Slowly shrinking while cutting
Photos	Same light and angle: front, side, back	Every 4 weeks	Visible change
Strength	Log weights and reps on main lifts	Every session	Steady gains when building; holding when cutting
Cardio	Heart rate and pace on the same route	Every 6–8 weeks	Faster at the same heart rate
Ability	Self-checks in Chapter 6	Every 6–8 weeks	Holding or improving
Recovery	Morning heart rate, hours slept	Daily	Anything clearly off

When to change the plan

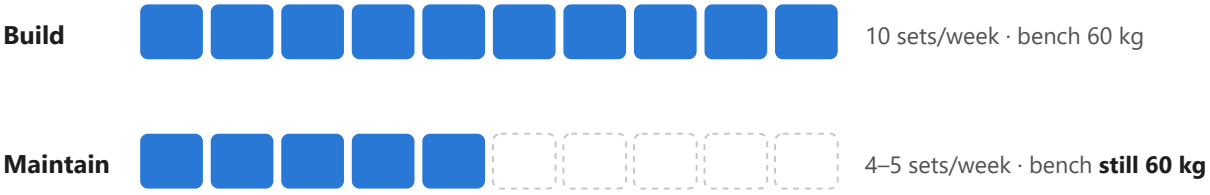
Wait until numbers stall for **2–3 weeks**; don't change course over a day or two of noise. Change one thing at a time (for example, 150–200 fewer calories a day) and watch for another 2–3 weeks.

CHAPTER 11

Maintenance and mindset

The years after you reach your goal are the real point of this approach. Maintaining is far easier than chasing, as long as your lifestyle can carry it.

Training for maintenance



Cut sets by half or more, **but keep the weight**, and you'll keep most of your muscle and strength.

Figure 12. Fewer sets, same weight. In maintenance, 2–3 lifting sessions a week is enough; keep cardio as is.

Eating for maintenance

- Once you reach your goal, return to maintenance calories for your new weight. All at once or a little each week both work; fine-tune using 2–4 weeks of weight trend.
- Body fat drifting 2–3% up and down is normal. After travel, dinners out, or busy stretches, just return to your rhythm. No compensating.

Keep the good parts

The feeling that effort pays off, and getting used to a little discomfort, are real gifts of training. Keep them. But there's no need to grade your body with scores or tiers; that turns into anxiety fast.

Warning signs for your mindset

If any of these sound familiar, chasing a physique has started to hurt your life. Ease your standards, and talk to a professional if you need to:

- Harsh guilt after unplanned food, or exercising hard to “burn it off.”
- Turning down meals with friends to protect your diet.
- Checking the mirror and scale over and over, with the number setting your mood for the day.

APPENDIX

One-page cheat sheet

Save this page on your phone and glance at it when you forget.

Goal

- Body fat about 10–15% (men), 20–25% (women)
- Waist under half your height
- Watch trends, not single numbers

Lifting

- 3× a week (lower / upper / full body)
- Each muscle 2× a week, ~10 sets
- Leave 1–3 reps; main lifts 6–10, accessories 8–15
- Add reps first, then weight

Cardio

- 150 min moderate a week (1 vigorous min = 2)
- Moderate: can talk, can't sing
- 1 interval session a week; 7,000–10,000 steps a day

Small doses

- Power: 2× a week, 5–10 min, fast, not breathless
- Mobility: dynamic warm-up before, stretch after
- Balance: 2 single-leg moves a week, 1 core move per session

Eating

- Protein 1.6–2.2 g/kg (goal weight if overweight)
- Half plate veg, a palm of protein, a fist of carbs
- Cut 0.5–1% a week, slower near your goal
- 80% whole foods, 20% flexible; creatine 3–5 g a day

Sleep and recovery

- 7–9 hours, fixed wake-up time
- A deload week every 6–8 weeks
- High stress: train 20–30% less

Stalled

- Check sleep and food first
- Then technique and rest times
- Only then change rep range or exercise
- Adjust after 2–3 weeks of no change

Safety

- Sore muscles: keep going
- Mild joint discomfort: lighten or swap
- Sharp or building pain: stop, see a doctor
- Busy week: the minimum still counts

Source videos (the original bó jī theory, in Chinese)

- Alan Shao (邵艾伦Alan), "How to build a lean physique: training, diet, and fat loss explained" (如何练出薄肌？训练、饮食、减脂一次讲透), from 7:39: youtube.com/watch?v=vQp8G-BHnI8&t=459s
- Alan Shao (邵艾伦Alan), "In conversation with Justin Sun: how young people can seize the AI era" (对话孙宇晨：年轻人如何抓住AI时代的机会？), from 3:12:05: youtube.com/watch?v=0Z-vhBvBmUY&t=11525s

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